

Unready for BATTLE

As tensions with Pakistan ratchet up, the army feels the lack of equipment which has not been bought for over a decade

| By Sandeep Unnithan |

Last week, army chief General Deepak Kapoor said the Indian Army was pushing for fast-track procurement of select equipment post the 26/11 Mumbai attacks, because normal acquisition procedures took "between two and five years". This was the first candid admission by a chief in recent times of procurement delays which are not only impairing the

army's modernisation but also impeding India's strategic options in case of an all-out war. In a recent meeting with Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, General Kapoor repeated his refrain. The army was unprepared for war. Asked about the option of a limited war with Pakistan, a senior general had a counter-question, "Are we ready?" His incredulity is not without reason. For the past decade the shopping list has been lengthening and the modernisation of the Indian military has slipped by

a decade. From basic equipment like night-vision sights for assault rifles to sophisticated surface-to-surface missiles which protect the advancing strike corps, nothing has been bought. Despite a doubling of the defence budget post-Kargil, the army is still embarrassingly unprepared. The chief's admission was also a tacit acknowledgement of the failure of the Defence Procurement Procedure (DPP), which lays down a 36-month cycle time to acquire weaponry—a deadline that is rarely met.

The CHINKS Modernisation has been affected, diminishing the military option

ARTILLERY

Wanted: 1,860
howitzers.

Worth: Rs 10,000 crore

Status: Proposals for wheeled, towed, tracked and ultra-light howitzers. Have been re-tendered after earlier trials were declared invalid. Will take five more years to buy.

